Yoga and Physical Fitness

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Introduction to Yoga

Yoga is an ancient Indian discipline of body, mind and spirit that combines physical postures, breathing techniques, meditation and ethical principles. The word "yoga" comes from the Sanskrit root "yuj", meaning to join or unite, signifying the union of the individual self with universal consciousness, or of body, mind and breath. Yoga originated in India thousands of years ago; the earliest references are found in the Rig Veda and the Upanishads, and the sage Patanjali compiled the Yoga Sutras, a foundational text, roughly two thousand years ago. Yoga is now practised by hundreds of millions of people in nearly every country, and it is recognised by UNESCO as an Intangible Cultural Heritage of Humanity, added in 2016.

When Is International Yoga Day?

International Yoga Day is celebrated every year on 21 June. The idea was proposed by Prime Minister Narendra Modi in his address to the United Nations General Assembly in September 2014. On 11 December 2014 the UN General Assembly adopted a resolution declaring 21 June as the International Day of Yoga, with a record 177 countries co-sponsoring it. The date was chosen because 21 June is the summer solstice, the longest day of the year in the Northern Hemisphere, a day of special significance in many cultures. The first International Yoga Day was held on 21 June 2015, when about 35,985 people performed yoga at Rajpath in New Delhi, setting a Guinness World Record. The Ministry of AYUSH, created in November 2014, promotes yoga and other Indian systems of medicine in India.

The Eight Limbs of Yoga

Patanjali described Ashtanga, the eight limbs of yoga: Yama (ethical restraints such as non-violence and truthfulness), Niyama (personal observances such as cleanliness and contentment), Asana (physical postures), Pranayama (breath control), Pratyahara (withdrawal of the senses), Dharana (concentration), Dhyana (meditation) and Samadhi (absorption or enlightenment). Common paths of yoga are Hatha yoga (physical), Raja yoga (mental), Bhakti yoga (devotion), Jnana yoga (knowledge) and Karma yoga (selfless action).

Three Common Yoga Asanas

Asanas are physical postures, held steadily and comfortably. Three common yoga asanas are Tadasana, Vrikshasana and Bhujangasana. Tadasana, the mountain pose, is performed by standing straight with feet together and arms stretched overhead, improving posture and balance. Vrikshasana, the tree pose, involves standing on one leg with the other foot placed on the inner thigh and palms joined, improving balance and concentration. Bhujangasana, the cobra pose, is done by lying on the stomach and raising the chest with the hands, strengthening the back and spine. Other well-known asanas include Trikonasana (triangle pose), Padmasana (lotus pose), Vajrasana (thunderbolt pose), Shavasana (corpse pose, for deep relaxation), Paschimottanasana (seated forward bend) and Surya Namaskar, the sun salutation, a flowing sequence of 12 postures that exercises the whole body and is often practised in the morning. Yoga should be done on an empty stomach, preferably in the morning, on a mat in a quiet place, and under a trained teacher for beginners.

What Are the Benefits of Pranayama?

Pranayama is the practice of regulating the breath, from "prana" (life energy or breath) and "ayama" (extension or control). Common techniques include Anulom Vilom (alternate nostril breathing), Kapalabhati (rapid forceful exhalations), Bhramari (humming bee breath), Ujjayi and deep diaphragmatic breathing. The benefits of pranayama include increased lung capacity and better oxygen use, a calmer mind with reduced stress and anxiety, lower blood pressure and heart rate, improved concentration and memory, better sleep and improved digestion. Studies have shown that slow breathing activates the parasympathetic nervous system, which relaxes the body. People with high blood pressure, heart disease or pregnancy should consult a doctor before practising vigorous techniques like Kapalabhati.

Physical Fitness

Physical fitness is the ability to carry out daily activities with energy and without undue fatigue. It has five main components: cardiorespiratory endurance, muscular strength, muscular endurance, flexibility and body composition. The World Health Organization recommends that adults do at least 150 to 300 minutes of moderate-intensity aerobic activity, or 75 to 150 minutes of vigorous activity, each week, plus muscle-strengthening exercises on two or more days; children and adolescents need an average of 60 minutes of physical activity daily. Exercise reduces the risk of heart disease, diabetes, obesity, depression and some cancers, builds bones and muscles and improves mood and sleep. A good routine combines aerobic exercise such as walking, running, cycling, swimming or badminton, strength training, stretching and yoga, with a warm-up and cool-down. Yoga mainly improves flexibility, balance, posture and mental well-being, and complements other forms of exercise.

Yoga in India and Tamil Nadu

Chennai has an important place in modern yoga history. Tirumalai Krishnamacharya (1888 to 1989), often called the father of modern yoga, taught in Madras for many years, and his students include B. K. S. Iyengar, K. Pattabhi Jois, Indra Devi and his son T. K. V. Desikachar, who founded the Krishnamacharya Yoga Mandiram in Chennai. The Siddha tradition and Tamil saints such as Thirumoolar, author of the Thirumandhiram, contributed to yoga philosophy. The Fit India Movement, launched on 29 August 2019, encourages fitness, and the Common Yoga Protocol is used for Yoga Day events across India.

Challenges and Future

Challenges include commercialisation, risk of injury from wrong practice and sedentary lifestyles. Research on yoga for stress, diabetes and heart health continues, and yoga is increasingly offered in schools, colleges and workplaces.

Quick Facts

- International Yoga Day is celebrated on 21 June; the UN declared it on 11 December 2014 and it was first held in 2015.
- Three common asanas are Tadasana, Vrikshasana and Bhujangasana.
- Pranayama improves lung capacity, reduces stress and lowers blood pressure.
- Patanjali's Yoga Sutras describe the eight limbs of yoga.
- WHO recommends at least 150 minutes of moderate aerobic activity each week for adults.